

Animal Progressivism: An Evaluation of the Status of Animals in Contemporary Society

Introduction

I have previously argued against the consumption of meat on ethical grounds. It is, I believe, the most massive, systemic, and unaddressed moral atrocity of the 21st century. Yet I believe it is also the one we have the greatest capacity to abolish as individuals. It is my hope, therefore, that this article can convince you, at least somewhat, to act against this injustice. In Section 1, I will address objections I have received in response to my previous article on moral vegetarianism. In Section 2, I will argue that even the mere consideration of animals entails the immorality of the animal agriculture industry. In Section 3, I will pursue an analysis of the origins of speciesism and argue against its moral relevance. Finally, in Section 4, I will advocate for why I believe we have a moral obligation to go vegetarian despite the seemingly causal inefficacy of individual actions. Though you should be able to understand the arguments I am advocating for in this article without prior engagement in any animal ethics or philosophy, I think it would be beneficial if you read my previous article on this topic for context, as this article will serve primarily as a response to criticisms and clarification of positions I argued for in that article.

1. Addressing Popular Objections

The most common objection against going vegetarian that I've heard from people is that meat simply tastes too good to give up and that they cannot do it. I will address this objection first because I think it holds absolutely no merit upon any scrutiny. I think it is important to affirm that, yes, the taste of meat is absolutely delicious, and plant-based alternatives will never fully recreate that authentic taste. However, we frequently make sacrifices against our personal desires in our day-to-day lives, even when inconvenienced or at the cost of something to ourselves, out of a sense of moral obligation. We return shopping carts to their rightful spot, we address strangers with manners when speaking to them, and we refrain from taking lost items in public places because it is the right thing to do, even if we are able to get away with such actions without legal consequences. Such actions are right in virtue of an asymmetry between the moral significance of such obligations and the moral insignificance of our personal desires.

To reiterate an example that I have written about before, imagine you are going on a walk one day in your neighborhood when you notice a toddler drowning in a shallow pond, not more than five feet deep. Unfortunately, you have just purchased brand new shoes, and if you choose to wade into the water to save the child, those shoes and the other items of clothing you are wearing will become wet and muddy. Given the options of saving the life of a toddler at the cost of the cleanliness of your clothes or keeping on walking, thereby letting the toddler die while

keeping your clothes clean and new, it seems that it is not simply a charitable act to save the life of the toddler; instead, it seems that we have an obligation to jump in the pond.

This scenario serves to demonstrate the fundamental moral principle upon which I will argue my case: if it is within our power to prevent something very bad from happening without thereby sacrificing anything of moral significance, then we *must*, morally, do it. Such considerations that I have just posited mirror the case for vegetarianism.

The conditions that animals endure on factory farms are abhorrent and inhumane. In a report by Gail Eisnitz of the Humane Farming Association, killing lines in slaughterhouses are so fast now that animals do not have enough time to bleed out after getting their throats cut before reaching the skinners and leggers. As a result of this, unstunned or improperly stunned cows that are still alive routinely have their legs cut off and skin removed while fully conscious, and unstunned or improperly stunned pigs are routinely lowered into 140°F tanks of water while, again, still conscious.

Such suffering doesn't begin at slaughterhouses either; far from it. From birth, animals are brutalized in factory farms, where they are forced to live in cages or crates in confinement facilities that are extremely cramped and overcrowded, usually living in their own urine and feces and never given access to the outside world. Such an unnatural habitat inevitably leads to intense psychological damage within animals, including cannibalism. To prevent this from happening, animals are usually mutilated at birth without anesthesia. Such routine mutilations include dubbing, debeaking, tail docking, dehorning, branding, castration, ear tagging, ear clipping, teeth pulling, and toe removal. Furthermore, animals are given a steady supply of antibiotics and growth hormones throughout their lives so that they can reach slaughter weight faster and are fed unnatural diets (that have been approved by the USDA), which include the ground-up remains of dead diseased animals considered unfit for human consumption, cement dust, and even animal feces. Because of this, many animals suffer from skeletal, cardiac, and metabolic disorders. Of the chickens bred for meat in Australia, 90% of those who make it to the slaughterhouse have an abnormal gait, simply because their bones cannot support the weight of their body.

We should be appalled by these conditions. Can you imagine a society that allowed for dogs to undergo these conditions daily by the millions? Such a society, surely, would raise international outrage for their cruel treatment of animals. But what is it about dogs that justifies our outrage at their mistreatment yet allows us to be compliant with our current animal agriculture industry? Any proposed standard for one's moral status that includes dogs and humans but not farm animals will, I believe, be arbitrary and fail to accommodate our intuitions on the worth of humans with severe cognitive disabilities. I have argued this point more in depth

in my previous article, and so I will not attempt to do so again here. If you are interested in my justification, I advise you to check out *Going Green: The Case Against Meat*.

Given these horrifying conditions, which seem very morally significant, and the lack of relative moral value we gain by eating meat, it seems we have an obligation to avoid the purchase and consumption of meat. You may deny the extent to which these practices perpetrate the animal agriculture industry. However, it is unfortunate that these conditions, among others that I have not named, are not marginal cases but instead the norm. According to the Sentience Institute, in the US alone, about 9 billion chickens, 120 million pigs, and 30 million cows are slaughtered every year for their meat. From these numbers, 99.9% of chickens, 98.3% of pigs, and 70.4% of cows are raised on these factory farms, enduring these conditions over the course of their shortened and miserable lives. Furthermore, four companies, Cargill, JBS, Smithfield, and Tyson, control 85% of the meat industry and have repeatedly failed to engage in humane practices surrounding the raising of animals for food simply because implementing more humane practices would be economically disadvantageous for generating profits. Here, I strongly recommend you, regardless of whether you have already made up your mind on whether you will continue eating meat or not, to watch the documentary *Dominion* on YouTube.

Given a full awareness of the suffering that billions of animals endure every year to provide us with access to their flesh, I think it is a moral abomination and is in no way justifiable that we continue to eat meat simply on the basis that it tastes good; such interest is beyond trivial when accounting for the process necessary to satiate our desire for meat. In the same way that we should not accept a slave owner's justification for violating the autonomy of another human by buying slaves and subjugating them to inhumane working conditions on the basis of economic benefits to himself, we too should not accept the meat-eater's justification for violating the right to life of an animal by buying meat on the basis of a pleasant gustatory experience for himself.

The second most popular objection that I have seen against switching to a vegetarian diet is that it would be bad for their health. And when presented between the options of choosing to benefit yourself at the cost of animal suffering or to suffer health losses in order to reduce animal suffering, the vast majority of people would choose the former option. Animals, according to those who hold such an objection, should not be considered at the same moral level as humans. Hence, we are justified in consuming meat since our interests should hold more weight than the interests of animals.

Though I do not fully deny the prescriptive claim that humans ought to have more moral consideration than animals (I will discuss this claim in greater detail in the section immediately below this one), I do deny the descriptive fact that a vegetarian diet will be bad for your health.

According to a report by the American Dietetic Association, appropriately planned vegetarian diets suffer from no nutritional deficiencies in comparison to an omnivorous diet and can in fact provide health benefits in the prevention and treatment of certain diseases.

In an article by Harvard Health, they claim that **“vegetarians, on average, consume less saturated fat and cholesterol and more vitamins C and E, dietary fiber, folic acid, potassium, magnesium, and phytochemicals, such as carotenoids and flavonoids when compared to those who consume an omnivore diet. As a result of this, vegetarians tend to have lower total and LDL (bad) cholesterol, lower blood pressure, and lower body mass index, which are all associated with longevity and a reduced risk for many chronic diseases, especially cardiovascular diseases.”**

In the same article, they also claim, **“In one of the largest studies — a combined analysis of data from five prospective studies involving more than 76,000 participants published several years ago — vegetarians were, on average, 25% less likely to die of heart disease.”**

Furthermore, **“Hundreds of studies suggest that eating lots of fruits and vegetables can reduce the risk of developing certain cancers, and there's evidence that vegetarians have a lower incidence of cancer than nonvegetarians do.”**

Finally, **“research suggests that a predominantly plant-based diet can reduce the risk for type 2 diabetes. In studies of Seventh-day Adventists, vegetarians' risk of developing diabetes was half that of nonvegetarians, even after taking BMI into account. The Harvard-based Women's Health Study found a similar correlation between eating red meat (especially processed meats, such as bacon and hot dogs) and diabetes risk, after adjusting for BMI, total calorie intake, and exercise.”**

In a separate study published by the NIH, Salehin et al. (2023) concluded that a whole-food plant-based diet will lead to a significant improvement in BMI, cholesterol, and HgA1C (average blood sugar) without energy intake limitations or exercise requirements.

In regards to protein, vegetarian options often have just as high, if not a higher, protein content than meat options. While tofu has 11 grams of protein per 100 calories, ground beef only provides 8.9 grams of protein per 100 calories. Additionally, tofu contains a third of the fat content when compared to beef and zero cholesterol, while simultaneously providing more calcium and iron.

Given that scientific research has not only denied that vegetarian diets are nutritionally deficient but has even gone on to affirm their various benefits in several aspects of our health, objections to vegetarianism on the basis of harm to one's health hold no persuasive merit.

As another, albeit less-popular, objection to vegetarianism, some point to the fact that animals in nature brutally kill each other in order to eat and survive. Given that it is a natural fact that animals can kill other animals without thereby assuming any moral blame for said action, and that humans are animals, it follows that humans can kill other animals without thereby assuming any moral blame. Vegetarianism refuted.

However, this objection misses several crucial distinctions. For one, it makes a categorical mistake in assuming some implicit relationship between what is natural and what is moral, and two, it is based upon a fundamental confusion between moral agents and moral patients. Let's delve into these distinctions and see why this objection against vegetarianism fails.

On the former distinction, it is unclear as to what "natural" means precisely. Is it truly "unnatural" for omnivores to avoid eating meat? This is surely not the case. Many of our primate cousins, such as gorillas, maintain an almost entirely vegetarian diet, consisting of leaves, shoots, stems, and fruits. If this is a natural fact, then why would it be unnatural for humans to also adopt vegetarian diets? Furthermore, history is scattered with appeals to nature or tradition to justify otherwise immoral actions that we now find absurd. Many in the past have attempted to justify slavery on the basis that it is a natural fact that some races are inferior to others, and hence it should be their role in the world to be slaves. Even granting that there are innate genetic differences between different ethnicities and sexes, it is not clear at all why this should be morally relevant at all. I have argued this point in far greater depth in my previous article. More importantly, saying that something is moral because it is natural is analogous to saying that something is moral because it happens on Tuesdays; there is a categorical difference between morality and nature just as there is a categorical difference between morality and time. Like how an action that is done on Tuesday cannot tell us whether such an action is morally acceptable or not, an action that is natural also cannot tell whether such an action is morally acceptable or not. Murder and rape are arguably natural behaviors, yet they are paradigmatically morally unacceptable.

Additionally, this objection, by appealing to the moral blamelessness of animals killing animals, confuses what it means to be a moral agent with what it means to be a moral patient. Again, I have discussed the distinction between moral agents and moral patients in far greater detail in my previous article, and so I will only do so briefly again here. Moral agents are able to act in accordance with morality due to some property. As a result of this property, they are able to be held accountable for their actions and, hence, can be subject to praise or blame for what

they do. This property, I believe, is rationality. Just as we do not think that a baby has done something wrong by peeing on someone, we should not think that an animal has done something wrong on the basis of killing another animal for food, since neither the baby nor the animal has the cognitive capacity to be rational enough to qualify as a moral agent. However, just because a baby is not a moral agent, this fact should not disqualify them from having their interests considered by those who are moral agents. It would surely be wrong for us to torture babies for fun, even if they lacked moral agency. This is because babies are moral patients in virtue of their capacity to suffer. Such a capacity is enough to qualify a being as a moral patient because it says, at a bare minimum, that being has an interest in not suffering, and therefore, as moral agents, we should respect that interest. Likewise, animals surely have the capacity to suffer and, hence, are qualified as moral patients. So even if they cannot be held morally blameworthy for their actions, we, as moral agents, must take their interests into consideration. Hence, we cannot violate their interests in not suffering or dying in order to satisfy our own interests to enjoy a pleasant gustatory experience.

As a final objection to vegetarianism, people have pointed out the environmental impact and unsustainability that a fully vegetarian economy would entail. While large-scale crop agriculture accounts for 9% of all greenhouse gas emissions worldwide, animals account for less than half of that. Hence, a society that adopts vegetarian diets has a much more detrimental effect on the environment and cannot be sustained for a large population of people.

This is, however, a grossly misinterpreted statistic. Out of all the crops grown around the world yearly, 38% are used for livestock feed. Of that percentage, 86% of those crops are deemed inedible to humans and are grown only for the purpose of feeding livestock, thereby consuming a vast amount of resources such as water and land that could otherwise be used to feed people directly.

According to the United Nations Environment Programme, the calories that are lost by feeding crops to animals could theoretically feed an extra 3.5 billion people, given that meat only provides about 17–30 calories in food for people for every 100 calories consumed by livestock. The world's cattle alone consume a quantity of food every year that equates to the caloric needs of 8.7 billion humans, which is greater than the current global population.

Furthermore, global land use for livestock accounts for almost 40% of the entire world's habitable land, which is almost as much land as forests cover on Earth. This equates to 38 million km² of land, which is as large as the total land area of the entire Americas. By eliminating animal agriculture and instead reutilizing that land for growing edible crops, not only could we entirely eliminate the greenhouse emissions brought upon by animals, but we could also reduce the greenhouse emissions created by large-scale crop agriculture by reducing the amount of land, water, and crops needed to feed the world.

In a study by Aleksandrowicz et al. (2016), researchers concluded that **“We find 14 common sustainable dietary patterns across reviewed studies, with reductions as high as 70–80% of GHG emissions and land use, and 50% of water use (with medians of about 20–30% for these indicators across all studies) possible by adopting sustainable dietary patterns. Reductions in environmental footprints were generally proportional to the magnitude of animal-based food restriction. Dietary shifts also yielded modest benefits in all-cause mortality risk. Our review reveals that environmental and health benefits are possible by shifting current Western diets to a variety of more sustainable dietary patterns.”**

In a separate study by Filippin et al. (2023), different researchers concluded that, **“According to evidence, a global change in dietary habits could be the single most effective and rapid intervention to reduce anthropic pressure on the planet, especially with respect to climate change. Our study applied Life Cycle Assessment (LCA) to investigate the total environmental impact of two plant-based diets: the Mediterranean and the Vegan diets, according to relevant Italian nutritional recommendations. The two diets share the same macronutrient rates and cover all the nutritional recommendations. Calculations were made on the basis of a theoretical one-week 2000 kcal/day diet. According to our calculations, the Vegan diet showed about 44% less total environmental impact when compared to the Mediterranean diet, despite the fact that the content of animal products of the latter was low (with 10.6% of the total diet calories). This result clearly supports the concept that meat and dairy consumption plays a critical role, above all, in terms of damage to human health and ecosystems. Our study supports the thesis that even a minimal-to-moderate content of animal foods has a consistent impact on the environmental footprint of a diet, and their reduction can elicit significant ecological benefits.”**

Given that all three prior objections fail to justify either the ethical or practical grounds for meat eating and the strong moral and practical considerations in favor of vegetarianism that I have made previously, I conclude that it is in no way morally justifiable to eat meat.

2. Granting Mere Considerability

I have previously justified the case for moral vegetarianism by first grounding my defense on the principle of equality between humans and animals and then arguing against eating meat on the basis of preventing unnecessary harm. In my last article, I stated that **“As long as a being is a moral patient, then the principle of equality demands that its suffering must be counted equally with the suffering of other beings.”**

However, upon further consideration, I recognize this viewpoint to be controversial for many. Such strong considerations for the interests of animals inevitably lead us to counterintuitive conclusions. Whether these intuitions are justified, however, is another matter altogether. I will consider the justificatory status of these intuitions below in Section 3.

Let us consider the following scenario: imagine you, your dog, and three of your friends were on board the Titanic when it hit the iceberg and had begun to sink. Unfortunately, due to the size of the lifeboats, they can only support up to four sentient beings. While you and two of your friends clamor onto the lifeboat, you realize that you must either leave your dog or your other friend behind to die in the ice-cold waters. If you attempt to bring both on board, the lifeboat will sink and everyone will die.

What is the right thing to do here? It seems that surely the interests of your friend or even that of a stranger should be given priority over the interests of your dog. However, if it is the case that humans and animals have the same moral worth and that we ought to respect the interests of all sentient beings equally, then we would not be justified in choosing to prioritize the life of a human over that of a dog or any other sentient animal. Surely, a dog or cow would have just as much of an interest in not dying as we do. Given that we have such a strong intuition that human lives are more valuable than the lives of dogs or cows, it seems that any moral principle that attempts to ascribe the same moral worth to animals as it does to humans is implausible. Again, whether this intuition is justifiable or not is beside the point, and I will address this topic in more detail further along in the article. But the fact that we feel so strongly that human lives are worth more than animal lives should serve at least as some evidence that we ought to prioritize the interests of humans over animals when both are equally threatened.

However, does this pose a challenge to the case against meat? Do the interests of humans, no matter how trivial, matter so much that it is permissible for us to override the most fundamental interests of other species? I will argue that it does not.

In rejecting that we ought to give equal moral consideration to the interests of animals, we are either left with the position that we don't have to give any moral consideration to the interests of animals or that we only have to give a non-negligible, yet not equal, amount of moral consideration. Let us consider the former view. While a denial of any moral considerations for animals might entail the permissibility of meat eating, it also entails an assortment of moral abominations. If you think that it is wrong for a satanist to gouge the eyes out of a stray puppy with a dull butter knife slowly for his own enjoyment, then it is clear we can wrong animals on the basis of them deserving at least some moral consideration. Hence, we can reject the no-considerability view as absurd.

Now that we have accepted that animals should be given a non-negligible amount of moral consideration on the basis of having at least some minimal moral status, at least enough so

that they do not get blinded or tortured for no good reason, we can tackle the question of whether this view entails vegetarianism. Notice here that I am arguing that we are under obligation to consider and honor the interests of all sentient beings, but not to consider those interests on *equal* footing with human interests. If we accept this principle as true, then we must radically alter our attitudes towards and treatment of other species.

Consider again the satanist who derives immense pleasure from gorging the eyes out of a stray puppy. Imagine that, after the puppy has gone blind, the satanist skins her alive and eats her. Surely, this is wrong. However, if it is the case that the sadistic and gustatory pleasures derived from the satanist cannot outweigh the dog's interest in not suffering, then it must also be the case that the gustatory pleasure alone we obtain from eating meat cannot outweigh an animal's interest in not suffering. This is perhaps, as some might object, disanalogous. When we eat meat, we get other benefits in addition to gustatory pleasures. Such benefits, when added up, *do* outweigh the interests of animals in avoiding suffering and staying alive. Let's consider some proposed benefits now.

First off, there is the nutritional benefit of eating meat. I have responded to this objection with greater empirical support in the section above, so I will not attempt to do so again here. But as a general summary of my response, we are able to meet all of our nutritional needs *better* on a vegetarian diet when compared to an omnivorous diet; the leading causes of death in the US and Europe are heart disease, cancer, and stroke, which are all strongly correlated with the consumption of meat; and vegetarians, on average, outlive meat-eaters by seven years and are less prone to degenerative diseases such as diabetes.

Secondly, there is the cost benefit of purchasing meat. Yet, this is also far from true. Beans and grains, which contain a similar or even better nutritional content than meat, are, on average, considerably cheaper than meat when purchased in bulk. However, since this is an empirical matter with widespread economic variability, I will not pursue it further.

Finally, there is the convenience of meat, given its availability and easy accessibility. Though it is undeniable that it may be inconvenient at times to be a vegetarian, this is more of a reflection of our society's emphasis on meat products than an innate flaw of the vegetarian diet itself. Consider the recent influx of plant-based meat-alternative options in fast food places. Such products were for niche vegetarians a decade ago and practically non-existent two decades ago. It has been because of the collective efforts of organizations pursuing legislative change and individuals boycotting meat that have led to the rise of these plant-based alternatives. Furthermore, it is sometimes just as inconvenient to eat meat (it takes hours to roast a turkey while it takes a few minutes to heat up pasta with fresh vegetables), yet this doesn't dissuade meat-eaters from doing so. If we can put up with the inconveniences of eating meat, then surely we can put up with the inconveniences of eating fruits, vegetables, beans, and grains.

But even if it were vastly more inconvenient to eat a plant-based diet, it is not clear why that should be morally relevant at all. If it is true that animals deserve some level of moral consideration, which I think is almost certainly true, then their lives and interests in avoiding suffering are surely more important than our mild dietary inconveniences. If this point is to be denied, then one must embrace the view that animals deserve no moral consideration, thereby entailing that the satanist who tortures and eats puppies alive has done nothing wrong. I cannot see any decent person who would willingly embrace this claim.

By accepting that animals should be given at least some level of moral consideration, we must conclude that we ought not to participate, directly or indirectly, in practices that inflict pain, suffering, and death on animals for trivial reasons. Given an awareness of how horrific the conditions of factory farming are, which clearly do inflict pain, suffering, and death on animals for trivial reasons, we have a duty to not directly engage in factory farming practices ourselves and to not indirectly support those who do engage in factory farming practices by paying for the meat that said practices produce. I believe that the only way to meet these duties is to completely abstain from purchasing and consuming meat from factory farms. Since we are committed to the principle of giving some level of moral considerability to animals and acknowledge that our current factory farming practices treat animals in a way that is profoundly immoral, completely unnecessary, and serves absolutely no significant human interest, consistency with our own beliefs entails that we *must* become vegetarians if we value doing what is right. The only question that remains is this: are you willing to live your life in a way that is consistent with your moral beliefs? Will you give animals the level of moral consideration that you yourself admit they deserve by refraining from eating meat? I have made my arguments clear, but such a decision ultimately falls upon you. It is only my hope that next time you choose what to eat, you take these arguments into consideration.

3. Against Speciesism

The attitude that many hold today regarding animals is distinctly speciesist. Speciesism, as I understand it, is the systematic discrimination of sentient beings and the prioritization of all human interests over all non-human interests on the basis of species membership. In Section 2, I presented an argument for vegetarianism that remains consistent with the intuition that humans ought to have a higher moral status than animals. I concluded that, by even granting mere considerability to animals, the weakest view of moral status that decent people can reasonably assign to animals, we have a moral obligation not to eat them. However, whether this intuition is justified is another matter altogether. It is my hope, therefore, to argue that it is not.

I want to begin this section with a very brief summary of moral methodology and general epistemology. Let me begin by defining what the term “intuition” means in philosophy. Intuition

is not, as we may come to associate with the word in everyday use, a sort of gut feeling that arises out of specific situations. Neither is it a sort of secondhand nature developed by professionals due to extended exposure in their field that allows them to recognize something without extensive thought. This can be exemplified in the case of chess players, who can identify a winning position on a board without much conscious consideration. Rather, the use of intuition in philosophy is best defined as a sort of intellectual seeming. What does this mean? To draw an analogous example, consider the faculty of perception. When I gaze upon a wooden table, it seems to me, on the basis of my perception, that the table is brown, which I then form a belief about on the basis of said perceptual seeming. However, we should not mistakenly identify seemings with beliefs. For example, when I look at a straw distorted in water, it seems to me that the straw is bent. However, due to independent reasons, I do not believe this to be the case. Intuition, likewise, is a cognitive faculty that allows for certain propositions to seem true to you given a deep enough understanding of the concepts involved in said propositions. For example, it seems that the proposition, "It is wrong to torture babies for no good reason," is true. We know this is true in virtue of understanding the concepts "wrong," "torture," and "good reason," even if we have never studied moral philosophy before in our lives. However, like perception, intuitions are not infallible. Consider the proposition, "There are more natural numbers than even numbers." While this might seem true to us upon first glance, it would be mathematically mistaken to form this belief, given we have independent reasons in the form of mathematical proofs that defeat this intuition.

Just like how perception holds evidential weight in the empirical sciences, such that our physical theories should strive to correspond to our observations in order to increase our confidence in their truthhood, intuitions hold evidential weight in philosophy, such that our philosophical theories should strive to be consistent with our intuitions in order to increase our confidence in their truthhood. However, given the fallibility of intuitions, we need to derive a method of arriving at the truth when our intuitions clash. Consider the intuition that an action can only be wrong if it affects someone negatively, along with the intuition that incest is wrong even when it does not affect anyone negatively. When such intuitions are inconsistent with one another, we need a method to discover which intuition should hold more explanatory weight. Such a method is called reflective equilibrium. The method is used as follows: first, we must gather our moral intuitions about a specific case matter; then, we check to see if these intuitions are mutually incompatible or not; finally, if they are, we revise our beliefs and discard weaker intuitions until we reach a coherent set of moral judgments. Let us go back to the example of victimless crimes and incest. Since these intuitions are mutually incompatible, we need a method to revise our moral judgments and conclude that either an action can be wrong even if it does not affect anyone negatively or that incest is not wrong.

However, before I discuss such a revision method, let us apply the method of reflective equilibrium to our current discussion of animal ethics. On one hand, we hold the intuition that

biological differences lack any moral relevance to the level of consideration an individual should receive. This intuition entails the conclusion that the well-being of a black person matters just as much as the well-being of a white person, or that the suffering of a woman and the suffering of a man should be counted equally. Let's refer to this intuition as the egalitarian belief. On the other hand, we also have a strong intuition that humans have a higher moral status than animals. This intuition entails the conclusion that the interests, well-being, and suffering of humans matter more than the interests, well-being, and suffering of animals. This difference in consideration matters so much, according to many, that it is permissible to raise and slaughter farm animals in order to eat their flesh. Let's refer to this intuition as the speciesist belief. Upon brief consideration, it is clear that the egalitarian belief is incompatible with the speciesist belief. The only difference between humans and non-human animals is their membership in the human species. Sure, it may be the case that humans are on average more rational and self-conscious than other animals, but it is undeniable that some humans are cognitively on par with animals or even inferior to them, such as in cases of humans with severe cognitive impairments. So such psychological differences do not separate all humans from all animals. Furthermore, the species difference is purely biological, just as racial differences are; it says nothing about the *interests* of humans or non-human animals, just like how racial differences say nothing about the *interests* of whites and blacks. Hence, if the speciesist belief is true and there is a morally relevant difference between humans and animals, then at least one biological difference must be morally relevant. This is incompatible with the egalitarian belief. Given that both beliefs can't be true simultaneously, we must make a revision: either we reject the egalitarian belief and conclude that biological differences sometimes are morally relevant, or we reject the speciesist belief and conclude that we ought to give equal moral consideration to animals as we do to humans.

How is it possible to make such a revision? Here, we can debate the supposedly different properties between humans and animals and argue for their moral relevance or lack thereof. Through this, we can check if the speciesist intuition is justified or not. This is the approach that I took in my last article, where I analyzed proposed methods of differentiating humans from animals and criticized them for failing to accommodate our intuitions surrounding marginal cases within humans. However, this is not the approach I will take this time around. Instead, I will argue that the causal origin of our speciesist belief is not truth-tracking, which thereby undermines the justificatory status of said speciesist intuition. What does this mean? To begin, consider that I have a belief that the Union won the Battle of Gettysburg. Imagine now that I discovered that I hold this belief only on the basis of ingesting a Union-won-Gettysburg pill, a pill that creates the belief that the Union won the Battle of Gettysburg in all those who ingest it. In the wake of such a discovery, I should suspend judgment on the matter of whether the Union won the Battle of Gettysburg or not, absent independent reasons to believe otherwise. What this thought experiment serves to demonstrate is that when we discover we owe a belief due to a process that does not track the truth on the relevant matter, we should think such a belief is unjustified. Note that this does not say anything about the truth value of the belief itself, only its

justificatory status. An off-track process might accidentally produce a true belief, but since it cannot confer justification on said belief, we cannot say that we *know* the proposition reflected in the belief is true, since justification is necessary for knowledge. We can say that a process tracks the truth if, one, the beliefs formed by the process are mostly true, and two, if the relevant facts were different, the beliefs would be different in a corresponding way. To demonstrate this, consider perception again: my perceptual beliefs are mostly true, and if the facts were different, my perceptual beliefs would be different. If there were no wooden table in front of me, I would not form the belief that there was a wooden table in front of me. Contrast this with the Union-won-Gettysburg pill. Even though it is true the Union *did* win the Battle of Gettysburg, had they not, I would still believe them to have won, since my belief was based on a pill that did not take into consideration historical facts but simply asserted its conclusion. Hence, the Union-won-Gettysburg pill does not track the truth.

We can now apply this same belief-analysis principle to our moral beliefs. Imagine that we come to the moral belief that incest is wrong on the basis of taking an incest-is-wrong pill. This discovery should surely cause you to doubt or at least suspend judgment on your belief that incest is wrong, absent independent reasons to think otherwise. However, instead of an imaginary pill that causes the person who ingests it to form the belief that incest is wrong, is there an actual process available to us that, when employed, does not track the truth? A very plausible candidate for such a process could be evolution by natural selection. Given the fact that incestuous intercourse tends to increase the chance of genetic mutations in offspring, the belief that incest is wrong would have helped our ancestors to survive and pass on their genes, and thus such a belief was adopted as a result. While this belief-formation process may have been useful for our survival, it would have done so regardless of whether incest was actually wrong or not. Hence, this process does not track the truth. Because of this, we should not take the belief about the wrongness of incest with too much weight. As a general principle, when we discover a moral belief that is formed as a result of a process that does not track truth, we are thereby unjustified in said moral belief.

Such arguments that attack the justificatory status of our intuitions on the basis of their causal origins are called debunking arguments. All such arguments follow this structure: Our belief that P is explained by X; X is an off-track process; therefore, our belief that P is unjustified. With the incest example, the line of reasoning follows: our belief in the wrongness of incest is explained by natural selection; natural selection is an off-track process; therefore, our belief in the wrongness of incest is unjustified. This line of argumentation serves to demonstrate that not all intuitions are created equal, and some should have more explanatory weight than others when attempting to reach reflective equilibrium.

It is now that we can finally tackle the justificatory status of our speciesist belief. I will use the general format of the debunking argument to make my case. Such an argument will go as

follows: Our speciesist belief is explained by X; X is an off-track process; therefore, our speciesist belief is unjustified. If there is a plausible candidate for process X, then we should take this argument into account and thereby discard the speciesist belief as a result when trying to reach a reflective equilibrium in animal ethics. Here, I will propose a possible candidate for X: an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance. While there may be other possible candidates for X, including an evolutionary tendency towards tribalism, I will not attempt to pursue an analysis of them in this article.

To begin, let us clarify what cognitive dissonance is and how it relates to what I will refer to as the meat paradox. I will define cognitive dissonance as a mental state we experience when our beliefs conflict with our actions. Because this generally leads to psychological discomfort, we generally try to either rationalize away our dissonance so that our behavior matches with our beliefs, or we accordingly change our behavior in order to be consistent with our beliefs. It is then that we can obtain a clear conscience. The most well-known example of cognitive dissonance can be seen in smokers. This conflict arises among smokers due to the fact that they simultaneously believe smoking is harmful while continuing to smoke on a routine basis. In order to resolve this conflict, smokers have two paths forward they can take: first, and most obviously, they can quit smoking. However, if they decide that is not an option, they can also revise their beliefs in order to accommodate their addiction. Such revised beliefs can include: smoking helps them socialize, smoking isn't actually all that harmful, or dying of lung cancer isn't that bad, since everyone will die of something regardless. Such beliefs, though awkward, help to resolve the cognitive dissonance associated with smoking.

Analogous to smoking, the consumption of meat also causes a degree of cognitive dissonance in those who eat meat (Loughnan et al. 2014). At some basic level, meat-eaters will be aware that eating meat harms animals, that they do not need to eat meat, and that harming animals is morally wrong unless we have good reasons for doing so (Plous 1993). The beliefs formed as a result of this awareness entail the conclusive belief that eating meat is wrong. In spite of this, however, most people continue to eat meat. Let's refer to this cognitive dissonance as the meat paradox. While some will align their actions with their beliefs and give up the consumption of meat, the vast majority of meat-eaters opt for the other option of revising their beliefs in order to remain consistent with their consumption of meat. Empirical studies have proven meat-eaters typically embrace two different strategies in order to do away with their dissonance. The first strategy is to deny mental capacities to animals (Loughnan et al., 2010; Bastian et al., 2012; Rothgerber, 2014). The result of this strategy is straightforward and effective: if animals could not feel pain, or felt it to a much lesser degree than we do, then meat consumption wouldn't be wrong since it would not harm animals. The second strategy one could embrace in order to do away with the meat paradox is to form the belief that it is necessary for one to eat meat (Rothgerber 2014). Again, the result of this strategy is straightforward and

effective: although eating meat harms animals, it wouldn't be wrong if it was necessary. These strategies thereby do away with the meat paradox.

Though the previously mentioned studies focused on strategies meat-eaters employ to avoid the meat paradox, it is not clear how or why the fact that people dehumanize animals or attribute necessity to their flesh should be relevant to the question of animal ethics; it says nothing about how we *should* weigh animal interests with similar human interests. However, the purpose of these studies serves to potentially demonstrate an interesting point: people make more speciesist judgments when they encounter the meat paradox in order to escape cognitive dissonance. We should therefore attempt to pursue this point more in depth.

Here, I draw upon Jaquet 2019 to test the above claim. The procedure and results for said study is directly quoted below:

“In each study, participants were recruited online and randomly assigned to one of two experimental conditions (a ‘control’ condition and a ‘manipulation’ condition). Each participant then filled an online questionnaire divided into three sections: questions about their meat-eating habits, where they were asked whether they ate meat and, if so, how often; a short vignette, followed by two comprehension questions; and nine questions probing their speciesist belief by asking them to rate their agreement with a target statement (e.g. ‘We should always elevate human interests over the interests of animals,’ ‘When human interests conflict with animal interests, human interests should always be given priority,’ or ‘Animals shouldn’t be granted the same rights as humans with comparable mental capacities’) on a scale ranging from 1 (Strongly disagree) to 6 (Strongly agree).

The first questionnaire, about our participants’ meat consumption, had two functions. First, it allowed us to exclude vegetarians. Second, it led our participants to think about their behavior, making it mentally salient and preparing the forthcoming induction of cognitive dissonance. Dissonance was then induced through a short vignette in the second step. In all studies, the participants in the manipulation group were presented with a vignette that highlighted ethical reasons not to eat meat, with a particular emphasis on the harm done to animals. Presenting the participants with ethical reasons not to eat meat just after having them think about their meat consumption was supposed to induce dissonance. In contrast, the control participants were presented with a vignette containing no reference to ethical reasons to avoid meat, in order not to induce dissonance. Thus, in Study 3, our participants in the manipulation group were presented with the following vignette:

‘According to some people, we should stop eating meat for ethical reasons. Their main argument is quite straightforward. First, it is wrong to harm and kill animals without necessity. Animals should not be made to suffer or slaughtered unnecessarily. This is basic

common sense. Second, eating meat involves harming and killing animals. Indeed, livestock animals suffer as a result of overbreeding, from dreadful conditions on farms, during transportation and in the slaughterhouse. And of course they are eventually killed. Finally, eating meat isn't necessary for us, as we can live perfectly healthy lives without ever ingesting animal proteins. As stated in the American Dietetic Association's official position on vegetarian diets, when appropriately planned, such diets are perfectly adequate from a nutritional viewpoint. In short, since eating meat involves harming and killing animals and is unnecessary, it is unethical. We should all go vegetarian.'

By contrast, the participants in the control group were invited to read the following vignette:

'According to some people, we should eat much less meat for health reasons. As stated by the American Dietetic Association, 'appropriately planned vegetarian diets, including total vegetarian or vegan diets, are healthful, nutritionally adequate, and may provide health benefits in the prevention and treatment of certain diseases [...] The results of an evidence-based review showed that a vegetarian diet is associated with a lower risk of death from ischemic heart disease. Vegetarians also appear to have lower low-density lipoprotein cholesterol levels, lower blood pressure, and lower rates of hypertension and type-2 diabetes than non-vegetarians. Furthermore, vegetarians tend to have a lower body mass index and lower overall cancer rates. Features of a vegetarian diet that may reduce risk of chronic disease include lower intakes of saturated fat and cholesterol and higher intakes of fruits, vegetables, whole grains, nuts, soy products, fiber, and phytochemicals.'

In Study 1, we used a very similar design, with the exception that arguments for ethical or health-based vegetarianism were presented indirectly through the description of an imaginary character, vegetarian for either ethical or health-related reasons. Study 2 took a slightly different approach by contrasting a description of livestock living conditions and suffering with a description of grain cultivation.

In all three studies, our hypothesis was that inducing cognitive dissonance would lead the participants in the manipulation condition to endorse speciesist statements more than the participants in the control condition. Our results for all three studies (Fig. 1) can be seen to confirm this hypothesis: meat-eaters endorsed speciesist beliefs more strongly when they were confronted with the ethical implications of meat consumption. As in the previous experiments, the reason is straightforward: if the interests of animals did not matter, or mattered much less than the like interests of human beings do, then harming animals would be morally tolerable even though it is not necessary. Meat consumption would remain harmful and unnecessary, but it would not be wrong after all. By adopting speciesist beliefs, meat-eaters thus make their meat paradox disappear, and with it the cognitive dissonance that it generates."

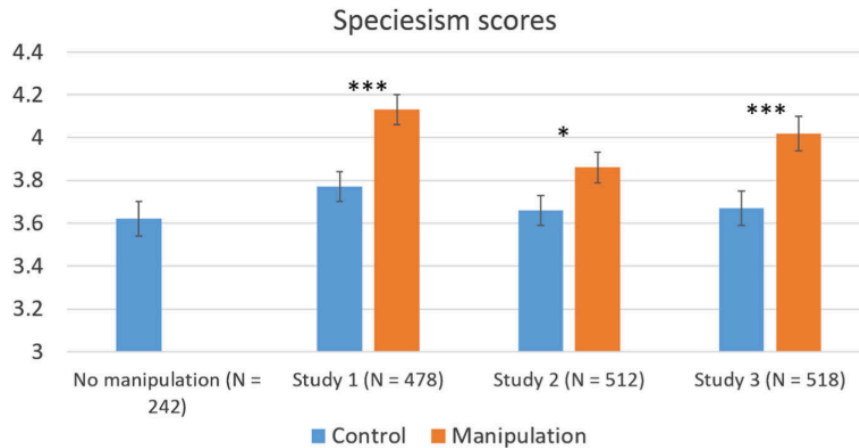


Fig. 1 Participants' speciesist scores in all three studies, depending on condition (control vs. manipulation). The scores were computed by averaging participants' agreement with nine statements (some reverse-coded) and can theoretically range from 0 to 6. For each study, we compared participants' scores in both conditions using Welch t-tests ($*p < .05$, $***p < .001$). The "No Manipulation" bar on the far left indicates speciesist scores for participants who were simply presented with speciesist statements, without the meat consumption questionnaire or the vignette

With the results of this study, we can now analyze what this means within our philosophical argument. Returning to our debunking argument, we can substitute "an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance" for X. The argument then will be: our speciesist belief is explained by an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance; an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance is an off-track process; therefore, our speciesist belief is unjustified. The first premise of this argument, "our speciesist belief is explained by an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance," is validated by the results of the study mentioned. The second premise, "an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance is an off-track process," is extremely plausible in that the process of reducing cognitive dissonance does not track the truth about how we ought to treat animals; such a process will generate the same outputs regardless of its actual truth value. It is a distorting factor, which means that it is unrelated to the truth. Hence, we should suspend judgment on the speciesist belief in light of the discovery that such intuition is the result of an off-track process, which thereby undermines its justificatory status, in order to reach reflective equilibrium in animal ethics. Given this, the egalitarian belief is the only remaining justified intuition, and we can conclude that the interests of non-human animals matter as much as the interests of humans. Hence, discrimination on the basis of species membership is just as wrong as discrimination on the basis of race or gender membership.

Now, to address potential objections to this argument. A defender of speciesism can attack this argument in a couple different ways: one, they could reject the first premise by asserting that the empirical data does not sufficiently explain our speciesist belief; or two, they could deny that an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance is an off-track process. Let's briefly consider these objections below.

In arguing against the first premise, defenders of speciesism could concede that, while the results of the study can show that speciesist beliefs are somewhat influenced by an attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance, it cannot show that they are caused primarily by it. Additionally, according to the data, subjects in the control group also provided speciesist answers, though to a lesser degree than subjects in the manipulated group, yet did not experience any cognitive dissonance. If the speciesist belief is prevalent even in the absence of attempts to reduce cognitive dissonance, then surely it cannot be mainly explained by it.

There are two lines of response to this challenge: first, even granting that the speciesist belief was only somewhat influenced by the attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance, this would still undermine the justificatory status of the speciesist belief, since the belief would have been shaped by a factor that is entirely unrelated to its truth.

The second line of response is to challenge the assumption that subjects in the control group did not experience any cognitive dissonance. Since all participants in the study were meat-eaters, they must also inevitably face the meat paradox, regardless of whether they were subject to experimental variables or not. The point of manipulation in the experimental group was not to *induce* dissonance, but to *increase* it by making it more noticeable. Therefore, we can conclude that increased cognitive dissonance increases speciesist beliefs. In addition to this study, other psychologists have found a correlation between meat eating and cognitive dissonance. Rothgerber (2013) concludes that the more people eat meat, the more they deny that animals feel pain or suffer in slaughterhouses. Bastian et al. (2012) concludes that people attribute fewer mental abilities to the species of animals they eat. The overwhelming evidence in favor of the idea that a greater consumption of meat leads to more cognitive dissonance supports the claim that the primary cause of our speciesist beliefs arises due to an attempt to resolve this cognitive dissonance.

Furthermore, in other cases where people's behavior doesn't harm animals, they do not hold such speciesist beliefs. Such cases include bullfighting, whaling, and dog-meat festivals. Because we do not engage in these activities, our behavior remains consistent with our beliefs, and hence the lack of cognitive dissonance also entails fewer speciesist beliefs.

Additionally, in the above study by Jaquet, vegetarian participants who were subjected to the same response variables as the experimental group scored much lower on the speciesism scale when compared to meat-eaters. However, defenders of speciesism could object that because this data is only correlational, we cannot know for certain via this study alone which direction causation runs. In other words, do people hold speciesist beliefs in order for their beliefs to remain consistent with their actions, or do they act as they do because of the speciesist beliefs they held in the first place? From other studies comparing the use of the same animal in different contexts, it seems the former option is more plausible. According to Marcu et al. (2007),

researchers found that while people tend to reject speciesist beliefs when thinking about the use of bulls and roosters in bullfighting and cockfighting, they accept the same speciesist beliefs when thinking about the use of calves and chickens for meat. Hence, it seems the moral value we attribute to animals depends more on our subjective motivations than it does on any objective property of the animals themselves.

These findings refute the claim that our speciesist beliefs are formed independently of the behaviors they attempt to justify. Instead, they seem to point to the fact that we form speciesist beliefs on the basis of trying to reduce cognitive dissonance by either demoralizing animals or ascribing necessity to their flesh.

So, instead of arguing that our attempt to reduce cognitive dissonance is causally irrelevant to our speciesist beliefs, defenders of speciesism may instead choose to attack the second premise of the argument and assert that attempts to reduce cognitive dissonance are not epistemically defective if they cause beliefs to form indirectly. How can they make such an assertion? Well, consider again the example of smokers and their belief that smoking helps them socialize. Instead of the interpretation that this belief is formed as a result of reducing their cognitive dissonance, one can instead propose that this belief is formed through rational reflection that is instantiated by said dissonance. On the latter interpretation, having noticed an inconsistency between their beliefs and actions, a smoker may come to question the reasoning for their behavior and, as a result of such reflection, come to form the belief that smoking helps them socialize. Since this belief was formed on the basis of rational reflection, a reliable process, it is thereby justified. Analogously, perhaps meat-eaters form speciesist beliefs on the basis of rational reflection instantiated by cognitive dissonance. If this were the case, then said speciesist beliefs would be justified to hold.

However, we can push back against this argument in two ways. As a modest response, we can grant the *possibility* of speciesist beliefs being formed via rational reflection while denying that this possibility doesn't weaken the debunking argument, since it has not yet been established as an empirical fact that speciesist beliefs are formed from rational reflection. Given this, it remains more plausible that these speciesist beliefs are formed as a result of our attempts to reduce cognitive dissonance, which, as I have shown, has been proven empirically.

As a second option, we can push back against this response in a more significant way by doubting the assertion that our speciesist beliefs are formed by a rational, truth-tracking process. Again, let's return to the example of smokers. While it may have been possible for smokers to rationally form the belief that smoking helps them socialize on the basis of rational reflection instantiated by cognitive dissonance, it would not be possible for smokers to arrive at the belief that smoking isn't all that harmful via rational reflection, given that such a belief is not grounded in thorough and correct reasoning. So, knowing that cognitive dissonance instantiates an

irrational and off-track process in the case where smokers form the belief that smoking isn't that harmful, it is quite plausible that it does the same in the case where smokers form the belief that smoking helps them socialize. Because smokers hold the former belief in spite of any compelling evidence for doing so, it is therefore unlikely that they hold the latter belief in a way formed by rational reflection.

While this could happen *in principle*, to assume it actually happens is ad hoc. Analogously, while it may be possible for meat-eaters to form the belief that the interest of animals matters less than the interest of humans due to a rational, truth-tracking process, it is not possible for them to form the belief that animals do not feel pain or that eating meat is necessary via such a process since they are not formed on the basis of evidence and reasoning. In assuming that cognitive dissonance instantiates an irrational, off-track process in the latter case, it is quite plausible that it does so in the former case as well. While it could happen in principle that we arrive at the belief that animal suffering matters less than human suffering via rational reflection, to insist that this is actually what happens is, again, ad hoc. While this defense may be disproved by further empirical research, in the absence of said research, we should assume that cognitive dissonance is an off-track process due to prior arguments.

In the battle between the egalitarian intuition and the speciesist intuition, a look into the causal histories of such intuitions has revealed the latter one to be untrustworthy. Given their mutual incompatibility and the need to resolve such inconsistencies in order to reach reflective equilibrium, we should reject the speciesist intuition as a result of prior arguments, which thereby only leaves the egalitarian intuition. Hence, we should deny that biological differences have any moral relevance to the level of consideration an individual should receive and thereby conclude that humans and animals ought to have equal moral status.

4. The Problem of Free Riding

Throughout my article, I have based a moral obligation to go vegetarian on the prevention of animal suffering induced by factory farming. However, this argument — that we should go vegetarian in order to reduce animal suffering — faces an important empirical challenge: given the size and structure of the animal agriculture industry, it seems extraordinarily implausible that an individual's decision to go vegetarian will have any impact on reducing animal suffering. So, even though it may be wrong to produce meat via factory farming, we cannot ascribe moral blame to those who purchase and consume it since their actions are causally inefficacious. This is the objection from causal impotence. If this objection is not addressed, it may be difficult to understand why we as individuals have an obligation to go vegetarian, even if the rationale behind the position is clear and correct. Therefore, we must resolve this objection if we want an explanatorily satisfying account of an obligation to go vegetarian.

In my previous article, I argued that even if our decision to go vegetarian had a 1 in 10,000 chance of reducing animal suffering, our actions would not be morally blameless given the amount of potential harm that could be done by continuing to eat meat. I hope to build on this account of vegetarianism as a moral obligation by clarifying why it is wrong to eat meat, given such low probabilities. In doing so, I hope to provide an explanatorily satisfying response to the objection from causal impotence. I will do this by granting that individual vegetarians are causally inefficacious while appealing to the wrongness of free riding in order to ground our obligation to go vegetarian.

It is undeniable that, as a whole, a sufficiently large group of individuals who decide to go vegetarian create a morally important good: the reduction of animal suffering. If one recognizes that this is indeed a morally important good but nevertheless continues to eat meat, then they are free riding on vegetarians. This is wrong because it is wrong to free ride, and it remains wrong even if one does not recognize the reduction of animal suffering as a morally important good. Just as we have an obligation to produce morally important goods through our own individual actions, such as by saving a small child drowning in a shallow lake, we too have an obligation to participate in its collective production with a group of individuals. This can explain why we have an obligation to go vegetarian.

But before we consider the wrongness of free riding, let's first consider the objection from causal impotence in more detail in order to see where the challenge to ethical vegetarianism resides. To better illustrate this objection, we must first consider the size and structure of the animal agriculture industry. Recall from Section 2: 9 *billion* chickens are slaughtered every year for meat, averaging out to 24 million chickens a day. So if I go to a restaurant and order a vegetarian option instead of something with chicken, my decision doesn't actually harm any chickens since the chickens in the restaurant are already dead. Furthermore, going forward, my individual decision to eat a vegetarian dish doesn't signal to meat companies that they should produce exactly one fewer chicken to accommodate my choice. Restaurants purchase meat in bulk from distributors, who in turn purchase meat in bulk from processors, and so on until one purchases meat in bulk directly from factory farms. By looking at this supply chain of meat, we can clearly see that at no one point are purchasing decisions fine-grained enough to reflect the lifestyle choices of one individual. Rather, reductions in supply only occur when a sufficient reduction in demand for meat is met. It is only when a certain threshold for boycotting meat is met that restaurants and stores will reduce the amount of meat ordered from distributors, who then reduce the amount of meat ordered from processors, and so on until it reaches factory farms, which then produce fewer animals to minimize waste. So unfortunately, my one decision to eat tofu at a restaurant instead of chicken does not meet this threshold, and hence no animal suffering is reduced. If going vegetarian has no benefit, even if it comes at a relatively small cost to myself, then surely we cannot be obligated to do so. Hence, even if we acknowledge the

abominable conditions of factory farming, it seems that we can ascribe no moral blame to omnivores given this challenge.

So, is there really any reason to eat tofu instead of chicken? In spite of the objection from causal impotence, I think the answer firmly remains yes. It is uncontroversial to say that vegetarians as a collective have an enormous impact on the reduction of animal suffering. In a 2011 study by Norwood and Lusk, in America, for a sufficiently large number of consumers, n , if n people decide not to buy chicken, $0.76n$ fewer chickens will be produced. Values for other animal products range from 0.56-0.91. So while our individual impact may be causally inefficacious, this is clearly not the case for the vegetarian collective. Recognizing and utilizing this fact is crucial to the vegetarian movement, and it will ground the rest of my argument for why we have an obligation to go vegetarian in spite of our supposed individual causal impotence.

However, we must address the difficult task of how we can bridge the gap between the fact that vegetarians do, as a collective, reduce animal suffering with an individual's obligation to go vegetarian in spite of the objection from causal impotence. In order to bridge this gap, we must demonstrate some relation between the reduction of animal suffering and individual obligations. And to do this, we must establish why we have reasons to help animals if our actions make no difference to them. I hope to establish such reasons below.

As noted above, it is an established fact that vegetarians, as a collective, are able to produce a morally significant good, namely, the reduction of animal suffering. So not only do we have a moral obligation to reduce animal suffering through our own actions, we must also participate in, rather than *free ride* on, collective efforts to realize this goal. While the former obligation is intuitive, the latter one may need a stronger defense in favor of its truth. To do so, let's consider a paradigm example of why it is wrong to free ride on the collective production of important goods, even if no one instance of free riding makes any significant difference. When we ride public transportation, it seems that we have an obligation to pay for the ride. So even if our own individual fare makes no difference to the public transportation system, the system would fail to exist if nobody paid for rides. Since the justification that paying the fare makes no difference to the public transport system is available to everyone, allowing this to exempt one from paying would thereby prevent anyone from having the good of public transportation. Morality does not allow such a thing to occur. Even if our individual contributions make no difference to the functionality of the system, this does not thereby exempt us from paying; we ought not to make exemptions for ourselves when the vast majority of other people can equally make the same exemption and where the universal application of this exemption would prevent the production of an important good. Hence, when we benefit from the existence of an important good, we ought not free ride on its production.

Does this paradigm example of free riding explain why it is wrong to remain omnivorous? There are two worries to this analogy. The first is that, with public transportation, it is because *I* benefit from it that I should pay the fare for it; those who do not use public transport cannot be guilty of free riding by not paying the fare. But when we go vegetarian, it is not us who benefit, but the animals we choose not to eat. So why is it that, in the former case, those who do not benefit from public transport have no obligation to pay a fare, but in the latter case, those who do not benefit from the reduction of animal suffering have an obligation to go vegetarian? Here, I think we should deny the assertion that we do not benefit from the reduction of animal suffering, at least when “benefit” is used in a looser societal context. It is clear that, while we do not directly benefit from poverty reduction or herd immunity from diseases that have no chance of affecting us, we nonetheless value these public goods as something we should strive to produce. Like the former two examples, I hope it is uncontroversial to claim that animal welfare is another example of a public good we should strive to produce. So for those who care about the reduction of animal suffering, we must not free ride on vegetarians for its collective production, even if our own individual contribution makes little difference. Hence, this response to the objection from causal impotence successfully attaches an individual’s obligation to go vegetarian with the wider moral good of reducing animal suffering insofar as they recognize that reducing animal suffering is a morally important good.

However, this defense of moral vegetarianism seems dependent on whether one cares for the reduction of animal suffering or not. The worry here is that it seems people can avoid a moral obligation to go vegetarian if they do not care about the reduction of animal suffering. But morality surely should not be dependent on our attitudes towards moral issues; not only do we have an obligation to go vegetarian if we care about reducing animal suffering, but we have an obligation to go vegetarian even if we *do not* care about reducing animal suffering. Callousness towards an issue cannot extinguish our moral obligations regarding them; serial killers who feel no guilt or remorse for the deaths of their victims and justify their actions on such a basis have nevertheless done something morally abhorrent in spite of their callousness. Moral obligations for the promotion of some good we care about always imply an associated obligation for the promotion of some good we morally *ought* to care about; a failure to care for the promotion of such a good thereby exhibits a moral failure on the individual’s end. Given this, our obligation to not free ride on the collective production of some morally important good is applicable both when we care about the production of said good or when we *ought* to care about its production.

If one were to deny the above argument against free riding, then it would seem we could absolve individuals of an obligation to participate in collective efforts where no individual makes a difference, even though the collective efforts of a group do produce a morally important good, the group is only able to produce this good because of the contributions of its members in spite of their individual causal inefficacy, and if the group produced the same amount of good but through a different causal mechanism that would thereby render individuals causally efficacious,

individuals would have an obligation to participate. To illustrate this point more concretely, imagine a futuristic society where, due to technological advances, every individual's dietary choice made a causal difference in the food production process. In such a society, morally motivated individuals who care about the reduction of animal suffering go vegetarian in order to reduce animal suffering through their individual actions, thereby severely reducing the demand for meat and, by extension, the production and treatment of animals on factory farms. Realizing this, factory farm owners reintroduce slack into the system, where thresholds must be met in order for demand and production to be reduced, thereby rendering individuals' dietary choices causally inefficacious once again. Though this makes no difference to the collective impact of vegetarians in reducing animal suffering, it would remove an obligation to go vegetarian if the argument against free riding fails. Hence, morally motivated individuals return to their omnivorous diets and, in doing so, cease to reduce animal suffering. This surely cannot be the case; morality does not allow for changes in individual causal efficacy to preclude an obligation to participate in morally important collective actions that are causally efficacious at the group level. Therefore, we should think the argument against free riding is correct in that it coheres with our intuitions about how morality ought to be.

Furthermore, the argument of free riding is widely converged upon by several competing moral theories. Perhaps most obviously, deontologists will accept the obligation to not free ride on the collective production of morally important goods since it is a foundational duty grounded in a requirement of fairness. Just as it would be unfair to actually free ride on public transportation systems, it would be unfair to free ride on the reduction of animal suffering, and therefore free riding is wrong according to the deontologist. Consequentialists should also accept an obligation to not free ride on the basis that individuals who participate in the collective production of some morally important good produce better outcomes for society. And virtue theorists can ground an obligation to not free ride based on the virtue of cooperation, where cooperation entails people must be willing to join in on the production of morally important goods. Since a host of moral theories affirm this obligation to not free ride, we have further reasons to believe in its truth.

Here, it might be objected to that the argument against free riding that I have just presented asserts that we ought not to free ride on vegetarians; animals are largely missing from the picture. However, we must ask ourselves why it is wrong to free ride on vegetarians. The answer here is obvious: vegetarians collectively produce a morally important good: the reduction of animal suffering. If the reduction of animal suffering were not morally significant, or if vegetarians failed to achieve this goal, then the argument against free riding would fail. But clearly, the reduction of animal suffering is morally significant, and vegetarians are able to attain this goal. The wrongness of buying and eating meat makes an essential reference to the moral importance of reducing animal suffering, and our obligation to go vegetarian is grounded in this fact. It is clear to see that animals are far from missing here; they are of primary concern for

vegetarians. Therefore, a concern for animal suffering grounds our obligation to not free ride on vegetarians.

Another objection against vegetarianism is the financial sacrifice in doing so. Though I am more than happy to grant that, if it were the case that going vegetarian would be a severe economic burden for someone or would pose a serious threat to their health, they would have no obligation to go vegetarian, these cases are extremely limited. For others, especially those living comfortably in affluent countries, going vegetarian would actually be cheaper than our current omnivore diets. Springmann et al. (2021) find that **“Compared with the cost of current diets, the healthy and sustainable dietary patterns were, depending on the pattern, up to 22-34% lower in cost in upper-middle-income to high-income countries on average (when considering statistical means).”** Furthermore, vegetarians do not lead unhappier lives, at least when measured by self-reported ratings of subjective well-being. Pfeiler and Egloff 2020 find, **“In these ANCOVAs, the effect of diet emerged only for one out of the five formerly significant comparisons (negative affect in Study 1, $d = 0.09$) while the differences between vegetarians and meat eaters in both satisfaction with health and life, as well as the effect on negative affect in Study 2, all became non-significant (d around 0.05). Taken together, the very small effects found in the t-tests for some components of SWB seem to be due to socio-demographic variables, meaning that the true effects of diet on SWB are non-existent or negligible.”** And, as I have established, vegetarians lead healthier lives compared to omnivores.

However, even if the argument against free riding works, I have not actually shown why we have an obligation to go vegetarian specifically, rather than merely altering our dietary choices. Since the obligation to go vegetarian is grounded in the moral significance of animal suffering, it seems that it would be morally permissible to purchase and consume meat produced on humane, suffering-free farms. This is, however, questionable. As I have stated above, about 99% of all meat produced in the United States comes from factory farms. Furthermore, according to a report by the Animal Welfare Institute, there are reasons to doubt whether “humane” farms are actually humane. In the report, Mathews claims, **“The animal welfare programs currently certified by the PVP as “humane” are not materially different from conventional production methods. They allow for intensive indoor confinement of egg-laying hens and meat chickens; ammonia reaching levels known to cause significant respiratory, skin, and eye disease in chickens; the painful debeaking of young chicks; and other inhumane conventional practices.”** A document by Mercy for Animals investigators **“captured the routine cruelties that are common husbandry practices in the egg industry, as well as acts of intentional cruelty towards hens by workers. These acts occurred even though Sparboe’s husbandry practices are audited and certified as “superior” for animal welfare by the United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Process Verified Program (PVP).”** Such common practices include, **“desiccated remains left in cages with living birds, ailing hens**

denied proper veterinary care, male chicks thrown into trash bags to suffocate to death, the painful hot blade debeaking of chicks, and the alarmingly callous handling of birds by workers.” Therefore, we can conclude that, in practice, there is little difference in purchasing “humanely” produced meat compared to factory-farmed meat.

However, this raises a further question: do we have an obligation to not purchase *and* consume meat, or *only* to not purchase it? In other words, if I find a perfectly clean and untouched hamburger in the trash can, is it wrong to eat it, given that it does not increase the demand for meat? I lean toward yes. It seems that, by publicly abstaining from the consumption of meat, I would more significantly contribute to the collective efforts of vegetarianism in reducing animal suffering than if I had eaten the hamburger. This is because my decision to publicly abstain from eating meat could play a distinct causal role in influencing the dietary decisions of others. However, my answer to this question is contingent on empirical matters, and it would require further research to determine the dietary influence of vegetarians on their social group. In the absence of empirical evidence to prove that vegetarians have no influence on the dietary habits of others, I hold that it is wrong to consume meat without purchasing it.

Finally, we must address the question of how demanding morality ought to be. Is it possible that we could absolve ourselves of an obligation to go vegetarian by donating our money to animal welfare charities or by devoting our free time to animal activism? Or does the argument against free riding also entail that we must go vegetarian, even if we donate to charity or partake in activism? As my argument has asserted, we ought not to free ride on the collective production of morally important goods. But while this may be possible for a particular endeavor we care about, it seems overly demanding if the argument also requires us to not free ride on the collective production of *all* morally important goods. This raises a deeper question about how demanding morality ought to be in our day-to-day lives.

On the most demanding view of morality, if the particular demands of a moral cause are not too costly to the individual, then we must meet all of them, even if all such demands add up to something very costly when combined. On this view, we must go vegetarian, since it is not too costly to ourselves, and we would have further obligations to any other causes that would not demand too much from ourselves.

On another, less demanding view of morality, morality can only demand so much of us that the aggregate cost of being moral could not be so costly as to preclude us from leading a flourishing and autonomous life in pursuit of our own individual personal projects and commitments. However, this view of morality asserts that, when picking between personal projects, we ought to choose projects that are more morally significant and do not leave us significantly worse off or conflict with other core commitments. In recognizing this, it is clear that an obligation to go vegetarian is consistent with this account of morality’s demandingness.

Since we must eat regardless of the decisions we make or the projects we pursue, and since going vegetarian is of little cost to the individual, it seems that becoming vegetarian is fully compatible with leading a life full of their own personal projects. An important disanalogy to notice here between going vegetarian and other forms of activism is that, while the former is fully compatible with one leading a life full of their own personal projects, the latter demands of us a sacrifice of our time and resources to the detriment of our own personal projects. Hence, on this view of morality's demandingness, while we would have no obligation to do activist work for moral causes we care little about, we nonetheless still must go vegetarian, regardless of whether we care about the reduction of animal suffering or not.

Finally, on the most mildly demanding view of morality, all that is required of us is to pay some aggregate cost in order to meet a moral threshold. Once that threshold is met, we no longer have duties to other moral causes. On this view of morality, the obligation to go vegetarian disappears insofar as we meet the moral threshold in other domains of our lives by, for example, doing charity work or any other activity that serves to promote good in the world. However, it seems that we have stronger reasons to engage with more widespread, uncontroversial, and immediate moral causes rather than less prevalent and immediate ones. If this is true, then it seems that we have very strong reasons to engage in the reduction of animal suffering, given that it is a widespread, uncontroversial, and immediate issue, and that going vegetarian is an extremely cost-effective way of reducing animal suffering when applied on a collective level. In fact, there are few other moral causes that demand so little of us to sacrifice individually in order to collectively accomplish so much. Additionally, we cannot take a neutral stance on the participation of animal suffering like we can for murder. It does not follow that if we do not join in on collective efforts to reduce murder, then we are actively murdering other people. In this case, we can do neither. This is not the case for animal suffering. If we are not actively participating in a collective effort to reduce animal suffering by going vegetarian, then we are actively producing it by purchasing and consuming meat. Here, neutrality is not an option; one must pick a side. With these facts taken together, it seems that, even on the most mild account of morality's demandingness, we have very strong reasons to go vegetarian.

So, on the first two views of how demanding morality ought to be, we have an obligation to go vegetarian. On the most mildly demanding view of morality, we have very strong reasons to do so. Having taken all these factors into consideration, it seems that the single most morally beneficial decision we can make today is to become vegetarian.

5. Conclusion

If you have made it this far, I would like to take a moment to express my immense and genuine appreciation for your time and effort in reading this. I know that you have so much free time and can do whatever you want now, given that it is summer, so the fact you chose to spend

that free time reading my article means the world to me. If you would like to learn more about this topic, feel free to check out the papers I have cited in this article or to reach out to me. I have no closing remarks since this article has been so long in the first place, but I hope you have enjoyed the read. Thank you once more, and please consider going vegetarian or, at the bare minimum, reducing your meat intake.